

Book II - The Spiral and the Block

Part 3 - The Eight Pillars

Chapter 22 - Pillar I - Life Is Decentralized

PILLAR 1 — Life is Decentralized

Series: Eight Pillars **Core Idea:** Reality organizes from the bottom up, not the top down. No living system requires a central controller to produce order.

The Thesis

Every living system in the universe produces order without a ruler. Galaxies. Brains. Ecosystems. Ant colonies. Markets. The internet.

The assumption that order requires central control is not a discovery — it is an imperial prejudice. The oldest one there is.

And the great religious traditions of the world encoded the opposite truth long before systems biology had the language to confirm it.

The Scientific Foundation

Complexity Science: Order emerges from the interaction of many agents following simple local rules. No commander is needed. No blueprint from above. Termite mounds. Bird murmurations. Slime mold solving mazes.

Systems Biology: Within what appears to be uniform tissue, dozens of distinct cell types — each running the same DNA but expressing it differently. Each contributing a function no other cell can perform. No cell commands the others. Intelligence is distributed.

The Brain: Approximately 86 billion neurons. No central neuron giving orders. Thought, memory, and consciousness emerge from the interaction of distributed nodes. The most sophisticated intelligence known — and it has no ruler.

How the Traditions Express This Pillar

Taoism — Wu Wei: The Tao moves without a ruler. Without force. Without command. Wu wei: effortless action in alignment with the natural flow. "The Tao that can be named is not the eternal Tao." The living order cannot be commanded — only lived in harmony with. Laozi's political vision: the best ruler is the one people forget exists.

Christianity — The Kingdom Within: "The Kingdom of God is within you." (Luke 17:21) Not in a temple. Not in a hierarchy. Not in an institution. Within. Distributed. Decentralized. Jesus consistently bypassed the institutional religious hierarchy and spoke directly to individuals — fishermen, tax collectors, women at wells.

Buddhism — Be Your Own Lamp: At the Buddha's death, his last words: "Be your own lamp." The dharma has no pope. No central authority. Enlightenment is not administered from above — it emerges within each person through practice, attention, and direct relationship with reality. Pratityasamutpada: interdependence — all phenomena arise in relationship, not from a single source.

Indigenous Cosmologies — The Web of Life: Lakota: Mitákuye Oyás'í — "All are related." Not a hierarchy of being. A web. No creature above another. Each essential to the whole. The living order is a network, not a pyramid.

Source Quotes

Direct quotes from Sage's own writing to draw from when scripting this episode.

"The spiral is the shape of a system with God as their king and the square is the shape of a system with false worldly kings. There is an eternal battle between the squares and the spirals — central control or decentralization."

"The difference between living things and machines is that living things just need to be allowed to grow and machines require constant effort to keep working. If you treat either as the other it will break."

"If we understand nature's code we could design things in nature's way not in the way of empire. We need to put together architects, civil engineers, economists, bioinformatics, computer science, linguistics, AI, philosophy, political science, spontaneous order, Daoism."

"People are like cells in a body — I will use that concept and apply the principles of bioinformatics to help guide people toward their individualized choices. Similar to single cell analysis."

"Every part in a living system has an individual purpose and no part of the living system is above another but they are all equal but perform different functions."

"Society is a living system and it should act as one. Structures should stay alive, not killed. Homes should be in the shapes of nature's growth, not the confining cubes. Cubes are the shape of slavery. The Fibonacci spiral is the shape of freedom."

The Living Age Trilogy